



Incident handler's journal

Instructions

As you continue through this course, you may use this template to record your findings after completing an activity or to take notes on what you've learned about a specific tool or concept. You can also use this journal as a way to log the key takeaways about the different cybersecurity tools or concepts you encounter in this course.

Date: 30/03/2026	Entry 1
Description	Documenting a cybersecurity incident
Tool(s) used	none
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. ● Who: an organized group of unethical hackers ● What: a ransomware incident ● When: Tuesday 9 am ● Where: healthcare company ● Why: a group of unethical hackers gained access to the company's systems by using an email phishing attack containing a malicious link, and after doing so they encrypted their files containing critical information and demanded ransomware, which is evidently financially motivated.
Additional notes	The employees should receive training that helps them identify phishing attacks and have frequent audits of the system's security. The company should not pay the ransomware, instead they could use decryption tools and

	recover their files.
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Date: 18/04/2026	Entry 2
Description	Documenting an incident
Tool(s) used	unknown
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. ● Who? A malicious actor, seeking to gain access to a device ● What? An email with malicious file attached to it, protected by a password that's stated in the email itself ● When? The email was received at 9:30 in the morning ● Where? It was sent to an HR employee via gmail ● Why? To infect the machine with a trojan malware and exfiltrate information
Additional notes	The severity of the alert was set to a medium and after confirming the file was malicious, it was further escalated to a level 2 SOC analyst.

Date: 24/04/2026	Entry: 3
Description	Investigating a malicious link

Tool(s) used	I used VirusTotal to investigate a link that was received through a suspected phishing email. This tool helps me analyze files, hashes and URLs for malware like trojans, worms, viruses etc without the risk of opening them; it uses the analysis of the cybersecurity community and vendors and judging by their scores and findings. Sharing information is very important in the community so malicious actors cannot abuse the same tactics and vulnerabilities. VirusTotal even has sandbox environments which can give a more accurate description about the behavior of a file.
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. ● Who? An unknown malicious actor ● What? A malicious file attached to an email with a hash ● When? The file is downloaded at 13:13 but a SOC has been alerted at 13:20 ● Where? An employee's computer at a financial company ● Why? The employee has downloaded and ran the malicious file on the company computer
Additional notes	VirusTotal flags the file hash as malicious with a score of 56/71 vendor score and -295 community score. The vendors have detected that the file is a trojan with the name of flagpro. The trojan would have sent data secretly to an external source.

Date: 24/04/2026	Entry: 4
Description	Using Suricata
Tool(s) used	I've used Suricata to examine and trigger custom rules in the role of a security

	analyst who must monitor a network. First, I typed the command <code>cat custom.rules</code> to display the rule that consisted of an action, a header and rule options. The action was “alert”, which instructs the IDS to inspect the data packets and send out an alert if any of them match the rules given. I also explored the meaning of other actions like drop, reject and pass. Then I used the command <code>sudo suricata -r sample.pcap -S custom.rules -k none</code> To run suricata using the rules from the file custom.rules, The -r sample.pcap specifies to use the mimic of a network traffic from this file and the -k none instructs to disable all checksums. Then I used <code>ls -l /var/log/suricata</code> to display the now existing 4 files in the suricata folder. I used the command <code>cat /var/log/suricata/fast.log</code> to open the fast.log file. The command returns the contents of the file which are two alerts, each line identifies the rule that triggered the alert, the time, the source and the destination. Un the next task I had to analyse the eve.json file by using the command <code>cat /var/log/suricata/eve.json</code> which returns the raw content of the file. Then I used <code>jq . /var/log/suricata/eve.json less</code> , yo see the information in a readable format. I used the jq command to extract specific data from the eve.json file using this command <code>jq -c "[.timestamp,.flow_id,.alert.signature,.proto,.dest_ip]" /var/log/suricata/eve.json</code> The alert signature was “GET on WIRE”.
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. ● Who? N/A ● What? N/A ● When? N/A ● Where? N/A ● Why? N/A
Additional notes	I also learned that with <code>ctrl + c</code> I can return back to the command line.

Reflections/Notes:

1. Were there any specific activities that were challenging for you? Why or why not?

Using VirusTotal was a bit intimidating at first as the details page first felt so confusing and new, offered too much information and due to that I had no idea where to look for certain information that I needed for the task. Although it seemed scary at first, I did spend some extra time to figure out which bits of information are the most useful and know where to look for them.

2. Has your understanding of incident detection and response changed after taking this course?

Yes, at first, I knew some theory just by reading the study material, but it was completely different to try and actually use the tools needed for incident detection. I've learned more about security incidents, the incident response lifecycle, detection technologies, types of attacks etc.

3. Was there a specific tool or concept that you enjoyed the most? Why?

I really enjoyed using VirusTotal and Suricata. What I liked about VirusTotal was that under behaviour I could check actual sandboxes running the file and finding out what processes it goes through and how malicious files behave. Suricata was very interesting to me, because it can operate as an IDS and an IPS. Seeing how custom rules get triggered and checking alerts was very intriguing.